

The Army Died in Summer

◆ The verdict

The French Revolution and Empire were extraordinarily violent — yet almost nothing popular history "knows" about that violence survives contact with the numbers.

The headline: the Grande Armée was **not** destroyed by the Russian winter. It was **three-quarters gone before the first hard frost** — bled out on the summer advance by disease, the collapse of some **180,000 horses**, garrison drain, and desertion. I hold this at **~90%**; the timing of the losses settles it, and even the winter's defenders concede it merely "magnified" a defeat already decided.

The Terror killed far fewer at the scaffold than legend insists — **~16,594 formally sentenced**, most of them commoners, not aristocrats — and far more in the provinces, where the Vendée alone cost **~150,000–250,000 lives** on both sides. That killing was exterminatory and state-directed, but "genocide" stays contested (**~70%**): the historian with the *highest* body count rejects the label, while the man who coined it carries the *lowest*.

Nor were the French uniquely savage. Suvorov at Praga, Britain in Ireland and at Badajoz, Russian peasants clubbing French stragglers to death — every great power did comparable things in the same two decades. What set France apart was **scale** (the *levée en masse*), occasional **systematic** cruelty (Jaffa, Haiti, the infernal columns), and above all **documentation**: Goya's 82 etchings and 420-plus memoirs that made French violence the era's defining image. The French were the most *visible* combatants of their age, not the most cruel (**~80%**).

One engine drives all four verdicts: **mass conscription powered the brilliance, the brutality, and the 1812 overreach alike.**

◆ The one engine: why brilliance and savagery share a root

Most histories treat French military genius and revolutionary bloodshed as two stories — the glory and the shame. They are one story, and both descend from a single decree.

On **23 August 1793**, with the Republic invaded on every frontier and in revolt at home, the Convention declared the *levée en masse*: "the young men shall go to battle; the married men shall forge arms... the old men shall repair to the public squares." Every Frenchman stood "in permanent requisition." It scaled the army toward **one million men** — a force no *ancien régime* cabinet could have paid for, fed, or imagined.

That mass is the engine. It fed three outputs at once.

LEVÉE EN MASSE

23 Aug 1793

~1,000,000 under arms

MILITARY MASS Corps system · meritocratic officers REVOLUTIONARY TERROR Vendée ·
noyades · infernal columns 1812 OVERREACH 600,000+ mouths · 600 miles

It made France **militarily formidable**: the corps system (self-contained mini-armies that marched dispersed and concentrated for battle), the fast operational tempo, and a promotion ladder open to talent — Marshal Ney was a barrel-cooper's son, Murat an innkeeper's. It made **internal repression** thinkable: you do not garrison, sweep, and burn a rebel region of 800,000 with a professional army of 150,000; you do it with a Republic-in-arms that has erased the line between soldier and citizen. And it created the **logistical impossibility** of 1812 — an army too large to feed off the land it crossed, in a country too poor and too vast to sustain it.

The French system did not "live off the land" so much as **strip it bare and move on before the bill came due**. In Germany and Italy the bill was small. In Russia it was infinite.

That answers the question the whole subject keeps circling: were brilliance and savagery separate French traits, or one thing seen from two sides? One thing. The Revolution weaponized an entire population, and a weaponized population is at once the most powerful army of its age and the most dangerous.

◆ How savage, exactly? A body-count ledger — and a counting trap

The numbers everyone repeats about French revolutionary violence are **wrong in both directions** — and the largest error is a double-count.

Donald Greer's foundational tally (*The Incidence of the Terror*, Harvard 1935) gives the Terror proper — June 1793 to July 1794 — **16,594 official death sentences**, of which only **2,639 fell in Paris**. Add prison deaths and killings without trial and you reach roughly **40,000**; some **300,000 were arrested**. A real horror — and a fraction of the "hundreds of thousands guillotined" of popular imagination.

Two facts detonate the standard image:

- **The victims were overwhelmingly commoners.** Greer's breakdown of the executed: **~85% Third Estate**, **~8.5% nobility**, **~6.5% clergy**. The Revolution devoured its own base far more than the aristocracy.
- **The guillotine was a minority instrument.** Only about a third of those killed for "counter-revolution" died under the blade. The lethal work was done in the provinces by firing squad and drowning — Lyon's *mitrillades*, where Collot d'Herbois and Fouché mowed down some **1,900** with grapeshot after renaming the city "Ville-Affranchie," and Nantes, where Jean-Baptiste Carrier ran the *noyades*.

Now the trap. Body counts are where history is most often, and most confidently, wrong — the running lesson of **Eighteen Bodies Short**. There the bodies went missing; here they get counted twice. You will see the Terror cited "all-in" at **~250,000** and the Vendée at "up to **250,000**," and a reader tallying French savagery is tempted to add them: half a million. **They are largely the same corpses.** The Vendée dead sit *inside* the all-in Terror figure — folding the provincial catastrophe into the national total is exactly how you reach 250,000.

Ledger	Figure	What it counts	Source
Terror — formal death sentences	16,594 (2,639 Paris)	Revolutionary Tribunal judgments, June 1793–July 1794	Greer 1935
Terror — incl. prison / no-trial deaths	~40,000	The round figure historians use for "the Terror"	Greer / Encyclopedia.com
Vendée — demographic catastrophe	~150,000–250,000	Both sides: battle, massacre, famine, disease, 1793–96	Lebrun / Hussenet / Martin
Napoleonic Wars — military dead	2.5–3.5 million	All armies, 1803–1815	Napoleonic Wars casualties
Napoleonic Wars — incl. civilians	3.25–6.5 million (Esdaile: 5–7M)	The full continental toll	Esdaile / Gates

Do not add the Terror's ~250,000 to the Vendée's ~250,000. It is one pile of dead, not two. The most common way to overstate French savagery is arithmetic.

Honest summary of the *domestic* violence: perhaps **40,000 in the Terror as usually defined**, dominated by commoners and provincial killing, with the Vendée its largest single component. And the Vendée is where the real argument lives.

◆ The Vendée: atrocity, yes — genocide, contested

The Vendée was a Catholic-royalist peasant insurrection in the west, erupting in March 1793 over conscription and the persecution of priests. By December the Republic had crushed it in the field at Savenay. Then — *after* the military victory — it did something that still splits French historiography two centuries on.

General Louis-Marie **Turreau's** *colonnes infernales* ("infernal columns"), operating **21 January–13 May 1794**, marched through the pacified region burning farms, crops, and villages and killing inhabitants regardless of age or sex — an estimated **20,000–50,000** civilians. At Nantes, Carrier's *noyades* drowned prisoners in the Loire by the barge-load; victim estimates run **1,800–4,800**, with total Nantes deaths cited as high as ~9,000. Carrier was guillotined for it in December 1794; Turreau was recalled, arrested, tried — and **acquitted in 1795 on an "obeying orders" defense**. That split verdict is itself evidence: the state neither consistently *willed* the killing nor uniformly *protected* it.

So was it genocide? Here is the finding that should reframe the debate — and that partisans on both sides bury:

Vendée death toll vs. the "genocide" label

117k 150k 170k 250k Estimated dead → (more counting)

Secher "GENOCIDE"

Lebrun

Hussenet both sides, ~25% "Blue"

Martin NOT genocide

calls it genocide rejects the label

Reynald Secher, who put the word "genocide" on the Vendée (*Le Génocide franco-français*, 1985, prefaced by demographer Pierre Chaunu), holds the **lowest** credible death toll: **117,257**. **Jean-Clément Martin**, the leading academic specialist, holds one of the **highest** — up to **~250,000** rebel dead — and flatly rejects the word, calling it "war crimes and abominable battles... but in no way genocide": a radicalized civil war whose massacres were a *dérápée*, an unplanned escalation driven by isolated detachments, ambush-rage, and a Committee of Public Safety guilty of "silence and

ignorance" rather than a written plan. **Jacques Hussenet's** demographic study ("*Détruisez la Vendée!*", 2007) — now the consensus — lands at **~170,000 dead on both sides, ~20–25% of them Republicans**. The more carefully you count, the *less* the killing looks like a one-sided plan — because a fifth of the dead were the Republic's own.

That inversion is the crux. Secher's 117,257 was demolished on method — Peter McPhee (H-France, 2004), Charles Tilly ("dubious methods"), Michel Vovelle, Donald Sutherland ("eye-popping gullibility") — because it assumes a constant birth rate while the population fell, assumes zero out-migration when thousands fled, and counts the "missing" against the **1802** census rather than 1794. The two most-cited "smoking guns" for genocidal intent are both shaky: Westermann's blood-curdling letter ("There is no more Vendée... it died with its women and its children") is **probably apocryphal**, and the alleged Committee order to kill "to the last man" regardless of age is disputed by Martin as evasive and unauthorized. The 1 August 1793 decree actually ordered women, children, and the elderly **evacuated**, not killed — hard to square with a plan of extermination.

My read, at **~70%: exterminatory, state-directed counterinsurgency violence, ~150,000–250,000 dead, genuinely two-sided** — the rebels ran their own massacres (Machecoul, March 1793, ~160–200+ Republicans piked over weeks) — but "genocide" fails the intent test and the 1948 legal definition, which deliberately excludes political groups and requires targeting a *national, ethnic, racial, or religious* group. The Vendéens were French Catholics ethnically identical to their killers, targeted as "brigands." That 30% is live: authenticate the disputed Committee order and the intent case strengthens sharply. Note too that "genocide" is a marker of French right-royalist memory politics — repeated National Assembly bills (Luca, 2007 and 2013, cosigned by Marion Maréchal-Le Pen) never passed — which is one reason academics resist it, and one reason the debate never dies.

◆ Were the French uniquely savage? The baseline test

Popular history codes French revolutionary and Napoleonic violence as a special European nadir. Set it against its exact contemporaries and the "special" evaporates.

Same era, other powers	What happened	Toll	Rewarded / punished?
Russia — Praga, 4 Nov 1794	Suvorov storms Warsaw's suburb; civilians massacred	~ 10,000– 13,000	Catherine II struck a medal ; Suvorov promoted
Britain — Ireland, 1798	House-burning, floggings, pitchcapping (burning tar caps), summary killing	~ 10,000 in 4 months (Bartlett)	Suppression celebrated
Britain — Spanish sieges	Sack of Ciudad Rodrigo, Badajoz (1812), San Sebastián (1813) — looting, murder, mass rape	Thousands	Wellington appalled but couldn't stop it
Russia — 1812 retreat	Peasants and Cossacks tortured French stragglers to death — clubs, spears, drowning	Uncounted thousands	French memoirs corroborated by Russian sources
France — Jaffa, 10 Mar 1799	Napoleon has surrendered Ottoman prisoners bayoneted on the beach over 3 days	2,440–4,100	Ordered from the top
France — Saint- Domingue, 1802–03	Leclerc/Rochambeau: drownings, burnings, sulfur-gas asphyxiation in ship holds, man-eating dogs	Tens of thousands	Contemporaries: "war of extermination"

The atrocity was **general to the age** — a feature of siege warfare (a stormed town was traditionally forfeit) and of counterinsurgency against irregulars who wore no uniform. On the raw evidence the French were savage *in the same way, and often to the same degree*, as everyone else; the victors of 1812 were no gentler than the vanquished.

Two things did distinguish France. First, **occasional systematic cruelty ordered as policy** rather than erupting as indiscipline: Jaffa and the Haitian "war of extermination" were command decisions, and David Bell (*The First Total War*, 2007) argues the Vendée was the first laboratory of a new, apocalyptic, all-or-nothing conception of war born of Enlightenment utopianism. (Bell's critics note the comparative frame is thin — even he concedes Spain "did not quite match the Vendée.")

Second, and decisively, **the documentation**. Goya's *Los Desastres de la Guerra* — **82 etchings**, 1810–1820, unpublished until **1863** — became the most influential visual record of atrocity in the modern era, and it framed *French* brutality for all posterity. There is no Goya for Praga, none for Scullabogue, none for Bengal. And Philip Dwyer counts **500-plus military memoirs** published in the first half of the 19th century, **420-plus on the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars specifically** — a perpetrator-testimony corpus with no rival in any other combatant nation.

Much of what we "know" about the era's massacres comes from the **French soldiers who committed them** — memoirs that recorded the horror and built the Napoleonic legend in the same breath.

The resolution, at ~80%: the French were the most *visible* and most *mythologized* combatants of their age, not demonstrably the most cruel. Visibility is not uniqueness. A ferocious documentary record — Goya's plates, the memoir avalanche — has been read ever since as evidence of exceptional savagery, when it is really evidence of exceptional literacy and myth-making.

◆ 1812: what actually destroyed the Grande Armée

The centerpiece — and where popular history is most confidently, most cinematically wrong. The story everyone knows: Napoleon reaches Moscow, winter descends, "General Winter" freezes the greatest army in Europe on the long white road home. That story is chronologically inverted. **The army was already destroyed before the snow.**

Some **600,000–685,000 men** crossed the Niemen in June 1812 (Riehn: 685,000; Zamoyski: 550,000–600,000), and *roughly half or more were not French* — Germans, Poles, Italians, Dutch, Croats, Portuguese. The "600,000 Frenchmen" of legend is off by more than half. Track the main striking column and watch it melt — in warm weather:

The melt — main striking column, 1812

450k 100k 10k

first hard frost early Nov

Niemen, 24 Jun · 450k Moscow, 14 Sep · ~100k Berezina · ~25k Dec · ~10k

before frost: ~90% of the loss after: ~10%

Charles **Minard's 1869 flow map** — the most famous statistical graphic ever drawn — makes the point in one glance: the beige *advance* band shrinks as violently as the black *retreat* band. His central-column figures: **422,000 set out, ~100,000 reached Moscow, ~10,000 returned.** Most of the

dying is on the way *in*. Wikipedia's synthesis puts it flatly: the main body "diminished by a third in just the first eight weeks... before any major battle was fought," and "the outcome of the campaign was decided long before the cold weather became a factor."

Milestone	Date	Main strike force	Killer at work
Cross the Niemen	24 Jun	~450,000	—
Before Vilna	late Jun	~10,000–20,000 horses already dead	Green rye → equine colic; fever
Smolensk	mid-Aug	roughly halved	Disease, straggling, garrison drain
Borodino	7 Sep	~28,000–35,000 more casualties	The bloodiest single day
Enter Moscow	14 Sep	~100,000	Two-thirds gone — in summer
Retreat begins	19 Oct	~110,000	Fine weather still
First snow	6 Nov	~55,000–65,000	The cold arrives to a corpse
Berezina	26–29 Nov	~25,000 effective	Escape, not massacre
Recross the Niemen	Dec	~10,000 in formation	—

The chronology alone convicts the winter myth. **Napoleon reached Moscow in September with two-thirds of his strike force already dead or gone.** The first snow fell on **6 November** — three weeks into the retreat, nearly two months after the army had been gutted. Of the ~440,000 lost from the main column, some **90% were gone before the first hard frost.** Winter destroyed the last tenth.

The real killers were four, and all four did their work in the heat:

- **Disease — the largest single cause.** Typhus and dysentery arrived with the army from plague-ridden Poland and were killing men before the first shot. Contemporary medical reports (J.R.L. de Kirckhoff, surgeon) describe the ranks rotting from the outset; campaign-long disease deaths run as high as **~220,000** (Montana State). *Which diseases is genuinely contested — see below — but that disease was decisive is not.*
- **Horse collapse.** The army fielded roughly **180,000 horses and lost nearly all of them — 7,000–8,000 dead by late June** alone, after cavalry let them gorge on unripe green rye and killed them with colic. Dead horses meant immobilized artillery, a collapsed supply train, and no reconnaissance. A **summer** catastrophe. (*The "300,000 horses" figure sometimes cited is simply wrong — the Grande Armée never had that many.*)
- **Logistics — "strategic consumption."** The strip-the-land model that won in Germany failed against Russian distance and scorched earth; the force bled out garrisoning depots and guarding a 600-mile line of communication.

- **Desertion and straggling.** Of ~500,000 casualties, roughly **50,000 deserted outright**, with enormous daily straggling under forced marches of 15–20 miles a day in summer heat.

The full ledger — ~612,000 entered, ~112,000 reached the frontier: **~100,000 killed in action, ~200,000 dead of disease/exposure/starvation, ~50,000 left sick in hospitals, ~50,000 deserted, ~100,000 taken prisoner** (many of whom died in captivity). **Combat was a minority of the deaths.**

The primary accounts confirm it. Armand de **Caulaincourt**, Napoleon's Master of the Horse — the man who literally ran the mounts — records horses dying and butchered for food and headquarters' dawning horror; his memoir, built around the sledge conversations on the ride back to Paris, is the indispensable eyewitness. Philippe-Paul de **Ségur** narrates the disintegration — the abandonment of Vilna, the mob at the bridges. Chief surgeon Dominique-Jean **Larrey** operated through Borodino and the retreat. None describes an army beaten by weather in good order; all describe an army already dissolved into a starving, typhus-ridden, dismounted horde before the temperature dropped.

The disease debate is live, and it matters. For years the villain was typhus — Stephan Talty (*The Illustrious Dead*) popularized "80,000 to typhus in the first month," a soft narrative figure, not a rigorous one. Then the science split. **Raoult et al. (2006)**, sampling dental pulp from 35 soldiers in the Vilnius mass grave, found **typhus** (*R. prowazekii*) in 3 and **trench fever** (*B. quintana*) in 7. In **October 2025** a new team (Barbieri et al., *Current Biology*; Rascovan lab, Institut Pasteur + Aix-Marseille) re-sampled 13 teeth from the *same cemetery* and found **paratyphoid fever** (*Salmonella enterica* Paratyphi C) in 4 and **louse-borne relapsing fever** (*Borrelia recurrentis*) in 2 — and detected **no** typhus or trench fever.

Read it carefully, because a hostile skeptic will pounce: this is **not** "typhus debunked." The 2025 authors say plainly that non-detection is not absence — "that doesn't mean that they didn't plague Napoleon's army." The sample is **13 teeth** from a **terminal-phase December retreat grave**, against ~600,000 troops. What we have is **two teams, one cemetery, conflicting pathogen IDs** — a real dispute about *which* microbes dominated. On the one thing that matters here they **agree**: disease, not weather and not battle, gutted the Grande Armée. The DNA doesn't rescue "General Winter." It buries him deeper.

◆ The winter alibi and where it came from

If the winter didn't do it, why does everyone believe it did? Because the man who most needed the excuse invented it.

Napoleon's **29th Bulletin** (December 1812) blamed the catastrophe on freak, unforeseeable cold. It was a face-saving document: to admit the army had rotted in summer would have indicted his own planning — the five-week dwell in Moscow (14 September–19 October) that pushed the retreat into worse weather, the decision to bring a force too large to feed. "General Winter" was a general's alibi, and both the French *and* the British press swallowed it whole.

People who were there contested it immediately. **Denis Davydov**, the Russian partisan commander, wrote an essay — *Was it Frost that Devastated the French Army in 1812?* — showing the worst losses came in **mild** weather. Sir Walter Scott asked why a commander so famous would fail to "calculate" for a Russian winter he must have known was coming. The modern verdict, from Allen F. Chew: the cold was "a substantial contributing factor — not a decisive one."

The reinforcement the myth cannot survive: the **Russian army pursuing the French froze in the same weather and suffered comparably — and won.** A cold that falls equally on both armies cannot be what destroyed one of them.

There were, in truth, **two destructions**. The summer advance destroyed the majority (~450,000 → ~100,000). The retreat — cold *plus* starvation *plus* relentless Cossack harassment — destroyed most of the remnant (~100,000 → ~10,000). Winter owns the second, smaller phase, and it was genuinely lethal there. But it inherited a broken army; it did not break a whole one.

Even the retreat's darkest set-piece is misremembered. **Berezina** (26–29 November 1812) is now French slang for total catastrophe — "*c'est la Bérézina*." Militarily it was the opposite: **an escape**. General **Eblé's pontonniers** built two trestle bridges in a freezing river (most died of it), and roughly **60,000 crossed** between two converging Russian armies before the bridges were burned on the 29th, stranding ~10,000. Napoleon extracted his core. A fighting river-crossing pulled off against the odds — a getaway that memory has enshrined as an annihilation.

◆ The brilliance question

The same scalpel that trims the savagery has to trim the genius: popular history inflates it into magic. Napoleon was a great **tactician** and operational artist — the corps system, the relentless tempo, the concentration of force at the decisive point, the *manoeuvre sur les derrières* that put an army behind its enemy, the massed artillery batteries. Austerlitz (1805) is a permanent exhibit in every staff college. The National Army Museum's verdict is the fair one: masterful at winning battles, far weaker as a **grand strategist** — no theory of how to *end* a war, no exit from the treadmill of victories that each bred the next coalition.

The record carries blemishes the legend airbrushes: the **Spanish "ulcer"** that bled France for six years, **Russia**, the collapse of 1813–14, **Waterloo**. And the invincibility was **manufactured** — the bulletins so systematically mendacious that "to lie like a bulletin" (*mentir comme un bulletin*) entered the language. The 29th Bulletin's winter alibi is only the most consequential entry in a career-long propaganda operation.

Here the loop closes. What made Napoleon look like a magician — moving enormous armies fast and feeding them off the country — was **the levée's mass plus the strip-the-land system, not sorcery**. And that system had a hard environmental limit. It won in the dense, rich, road-laced theaters of Germany and Italy, where the next town's granary was always in reach. It **failed catastrophically in Spain and Russia**, against distance, poverty, and scorched earth. The genius was **context-dependent** — and the context that broke it was the very scale the Revolution had handed him. The engine that made the brilliance possible also set the trap.

◆ The strongest case against this verdict

An honest verdict has to survive its own steelman. Here is the opposite of everything above.

Maybe winter really was decisive. The retreat losses were real and enormous — ~100,000 down to ~10,000 — and they *did* fall largely in worsening cold, men freezing at Berezina and in the -25°C nights of early December. Had Napoleon left Moscow in September instead of lingering five weeks, more would have survived; the cold was the difference between a hard retreat and a death march. The "summer attrition" school may overcorrect: a *reduced* army that gets home is a defeat, an *annihilated* one is a catastrophe — and winter turned the former into the latter. **My answer:** partly conceded — this is the "two destructions" framing, and winter genuinely owns the second phase. But it cannot be the *primary* cause of losing ~440,000 men when ~90% were gone before it arrived, and "the Russians froze too and won" is fatal to the strong version. I hold the summer thesis at ~90%, not 100%, precisely because the retreat is a real winter story.

Maybe the French were uniquely savage. The systematic cases don't file easily under "typical." Jaffa was a top-ordered massacre of surrendered prisoners. Haiti featured sulfur-gas asphyxiation and a stated plan to exterminate an adult population — arguably a preview of 20th-century industrialized atrocity. The infernal columns operated *after* military victory, reading as punitive extermination rather than the fog of a stormed town. Bell's "first total war" thesis holds that France didn't do more of the same but invented a new, ideological, boundary-dissolving *kind* of war. **My answer:** these are the strongest 20% against me, and I take them seriously — but every power has its Jaffa (Suvorov's Praga earned a medal), and Bell's own reviewers fault his thin comparative frame. Distinctive in *character* in specific episodes; not distinctive in *degree* enough to call the French uniquely savage.

Maybe Napoleon was a singular genius and the Vendée was genocide. The genius camp can point to a decade of beating every army in Europe in turn; "unlucky at Russia" has real force. The genocide camp can note that Martin, for all his rejection of the word, documents tens of thousands of civilians deliberately slaughtered by state columns after the war was won — if that is not genocide, what is the word *for*? **My answer:** the genius was real but context-bounded and self-mythologized; "singular" overstates it. The genocide question turns on the 1948 definition and on provable central intent, both of which fail — but I hold this at only ~70% because the Committee of Public Safety's exact orders on non-combatants remain murky, and if the disputed "to the last man" directive were authenticated, I would move.

◆ What would change this answer

- **On 1812 (~90%):** A reconstruction of losses by cause *and date* showing a far larger share of deaths after the first hard frost than the current chronology implies — contemporary muster rolls proving the army was still ~250,000 strong in early November, say. Nothing in the record hints at it; it would take a genuine archival surprise.
- **On the disease story:** Large-scale ancient-DNA sampling across *multiple* 1812 graves — advance-route as well as retreat-route — recovering a dominant pathogen signal. Typhus turning up broadly on the *advance* revives Talty; paratyphoid/relapsing fever dominating everywhere generalizes the 2025 result. The current 13-tooth, single-cemetery sample is far too thin to settle it.
- **On the Vendée (~70%):** Authentication of a Committee of Public Safety order explicitly directing the killing of women, children, and non-combatants *as such* would push me toward "genocide."

Firmer demographic work confirming the ~20–25% Republican share of the dead would harden the "civil war, not genocide" reading.

- **On uniqueness (~80%):** A quantitative comparison of *ordered-as-policy* atrocities across France, Britain, Russia, and Austria in 1792–1815, controlling for the documentation asymmetry. If French command-ordered civilian killing proved an order of magnitude more frequent than rivals', I'd upgrade "distinctive in episodes" toward "distinctive in kind."
- **On brilliance:** Little would move this — Spain, Russia, 1814, and Waterloo are fixed. Evidence of a coherent Napoleonic *war-termination* strategy, a plan for peace behind the victories, would soften "great tactician, weak strategist."

The load-bearing conclusion — **the Grande Armée died on the summer road, not in the winter snow** — is the most secure claim here, and the one popular history gets most spectacularly backwards. As with the world's oldest fire: the number everyone repeats with total confidence is the one nobody actually checked.

◆ Sources, annotated

- **French invasion of Russia** — [Wikipedia](#) — The spine of the 1812 chronology and casualty ledger; states plainly that the outcome was decided before the cold. Well-sourced synthesis — high trust for orientation, verify specific figures downstream.
- **Institut Pasteur — 2025 DNA study** [press release](#) — Primary announcement of the paratyphoid + relapsing-fever finding (Barbieri et al., *Current Biology*, 24 Oct 2025). Authoritative on the new result; read with the caveats.
- **CNN — Napoleon's army undetected disease** — Carries the crucial author quote that non-detection ≠ absence. Reliable science journalism; the corrective to over-reading the 2025 study.
- **Raoult et al. 2006** — [louse-borne disease, Vilnius grave](#) — The earlier team that *did* find typhus and trench fever in the same cemetery. Peer-reviewed; why the pathogen question is live, not settled.
- **Russia Beyond — "No, winter DIDN'T destroy Napoleon's army"** — Accessible statement of the revisionist chronology and the mild-early-winter meteorology. Popular outlet, Russian POV; the underlying facts check out against scholarship.
- **Montana State University — Typhus and Napoleon in Russia** — Source for summer disease attrition and the ~220,000 disease-death estimate. Academic teaching resource; solid on the disease-centric thesis.
- **Minard's 1869 flow map** — [Age of Revolution](#) — The one-image proof that advance losses matched retreat losses (422k → 100k → 10k). The primary graphic; read its 10,000 as the central column, not total survivors.
- **Battle of Berezina** — [Wikipedia](#) — Confirms the crossing as an escape (~60k crossed, ~25k effective), not an annihilation. Reliable; corrects the "Bérézina = disaster" idiom.
- **Reign of Terror** — [Wikipedia](#) — Greer's 16,594 / 2,639-Paris figures and the arrest numbers. Solid digest of the standard scholarship on the Terror's true scale.

- **The Conversation — most people killed were commoners** — The class-composition correction: the guillotine's victims were mostly Third Estate. Academic authorship; trustworthy myth-busting.
- **War in the Vendée — Wikipedia** — The competing death tolls (Secher/Lebrun/Hussenet/Martin) and the noyades / infernal-columns detail. Good on the range; note the genocide debate is politically charged.
- **Reynald Secher — Wikipedia** — Documents Secher's 117,257, his genocide thesis, and the academic pushback. Useful for the minority view *and* its critics.
- **Peter McPhee, H-France Review (2004)** — The standard scholarly demolition of Secher's demographic method. Peer-reviewed; the single best rebuttal to cite.
- **Philip Dwyer, "It Still Makes Me Shudder," War in History (2009)** — The memoir-corpus argument (420+ Napoleonic memoirs) behind the documentation asymmetry. Leading specialist; the backbone of the "visible, not unique" case. (Pair with Dwyer's 2013 *Journal of Genocide Research* piece on [Haitian atrocities](#).)
- **The Disasters of War — Wikipedia** — Goya's 82 plates, 1810–20, published 1863 — the visual record that fixed French brutality in memory. Reliable on the facts of the series.
- **National Army Museum — Napoleon: military genius?** — The balanced verdict: masterful tactician, weaker strategist, self-propagandized reputation. Institutional and even-handed; anchors the brilliance section.